

Argentina



Argentina occupies most of southern South America. After 30 years of intermittent military rule, democracy returned in 1983. Economy has slowed since its recovery from 2001 crash.



GEOGRAPHY

The Andes form a natural border with Chile in the west. East are the heavily wooded plains (Gran Chaco) and treeless but fertile Pampas plains. Bleak and arid Patagonia in the south.



CLIMATE

The Andes are semiarid in the north and snowy in the south. Pampas have a mild climate with summer rains.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

People are largely of European descent; over one-third are of Italian origin. Indigenous peoples are now in a minority, living mainly in Andean regions or in the Gran Chaco. The middle classes were worst hit by the economic meltdown of 2001–2002.



INSIGHT: *The Tango originated in the poorer quarters of Buenos Aires at the end of the 19th century*



THE ECONOMY

Agricultural exports restored growth from 2003, but bad drought in 2008 coincided with global downturn.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Republic of Argentina

DATE OF FORMATION: 1816

CAPITAL: Buenos Aires

POPULATION: 40.3 million

TOTAL AREA: 1,068,296 sq. miles
(2,766,890 sq. km)

DENSITY: 38 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Spanish*, Italian, Amerindian languages

RELIGIONS: Roman Catholic 90%, other 6%, Protestant 2%, Jewish 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Indo-European 83%, Mestizo 14%, Jewish 2%, Amerindian 1%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Argentine peso = 100 centavos